

▲ THANGA TAMILSELVAN, *63*

| DMK | *Theni, Tamil Nadu*

Warning: Dravidian alphabet soup ahead. Tamilselvan's shift from the AMMK, a breakaway faction of the AIADMK, to the DMK enabled its alliance to clinch the only seat it had lost in 2019. Giant leap for one who's made headlines in 2001 as the AIADMK MLA from Andipatti who sacrificed his seat to allow then CM J. Jayalalithaa to contest a bypoll. That endeared him to the AIADMK supremo—duly rewarded with a Rajya Sabha seat, he returned to represent Andipatti in 2011 and 2016. Post-Jaya, he joined the AMMK but lost from Theni in 2019. That triangle now comes a full circle.

▼ VIRENDRA SINGH, *65*

| SP | *Chandauli, UP*

This Banarasiya—from Chiraigaon, pretty much within the holy town's extended parikrama—was presumably schooled in BHU student affairs to be undogmatic about political choices. He got to be an MLA with the Congress (his original habitat) in 1996, was part of the short-lived splinter called Loktantrik Congress that backed Kalyan Singh's BJP regime (where he got to be minister), stayed back when the splinter splintered further, then tossed his hat in the BSP ring to become MLA again, then arrived at the SP to be a minister under Mulayam Yadav but didn't build a pucca house yet. A rumoured return to the Congress and another BSP detour intervened before his flight landed, with ideological baggage deemed solid enough to be made national spokesman.



▼ SANJAY DESHMUKH, 55

| SS (UBT) | *Yavatmal-Washim, Maharashtra*



He may well qualify for the Maharashtra title bout for being an 'Aya Ram, Gaya Ram'—no small feat. When the Shiv Sena took root in Vidarbha, Deshmukh was among those who joined its ranks and duly rose to be its Yavatmal district chief. He was elected to the assembly twice (1999, 2004)—but as an Independent, defeating the official Sena nominee, Shrikant Munginwar. Deshmukh has been a long-time opponent of another Sanjay (Rathod), the soil and water conservation minister who defeated him in 2009. At that time, Deshmukh was with the Congress. He later joined the BJP, only to pivot to Uddhav Thackeray's Sena after Rathod joined Shinde's Sena. Hope that clarifies things.

▶ JITENDRA KUMAR DOHARE, *54*

| SP | *Etawah (SC), UP*



The home base of UP's Yadav dynasty is an SC-reserved seat, so the Samajwadis chose a 2020 import from the BSP, a strong organisation man who lists "farming, contractor work and public service" as professions and whose sister chairs a panchayat with 91 villages under its purview. It worked.

▶ PRADEEP KUMAR PANIGRAHY, *61*

| BJP | *Berhampur, Odisha*



The Naveen Patnaik loyalist, three-time Gopalpur MLA and ex-minister was expelled from the BJD in 2020 due to "anti-people activities". He joined the BJP in February and defeated his closest rival, Rasmi Ranjan Patnaik, of the Congress. Trained as a lawyer, he has a PhD in Conservation of Biodiversity under International Law with Special Reference to India. Maybe it has applications in political science too.